



Exploring Gender's Impact on Career Trajectories in Nepal's Civil Service Sector

Shyam Sundar Yadav ¹, Binod Kumar Adhikari ², Shyam Kishor Mahto ³

¹Ministry of Agriculture and Livestock Development, Singh Durbar, Kathmandu

²Central Department of Computer Science and Information Technology, TU

³Exam Controller, Rajarshi Janak University

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ABSTRACT

Background: Gender encompasses the societal, cultural, and psychological traits and roles associated with being male, female, or non-binary, separate from biological sex. It plays a significant role in influencing various aspects of an individual's life, thought, and career development, including their actions, opportunities, and experiences. This study specifically aimed to determine the association between gender and pressure to conform to traditional roles in both personal and professional life, investigate gender discrimination in the workplace, and examine the influence of gender on career development through career path choices.

Method: This phenomenological study employed a quantitative research design and was conducted from May 20 to 27, 2024, at the Department of Livestock Services (DLS), Hariharbawan, Lalitpur. Data were collected using a closed-ended questionnaire administered via Google Forms. As the small population size ($N < 100$), approximately 66.67% of the population was taken as a sample to enhance precision. A list of the population ($N = 45$) was prepared. The MOD function " $=MOD(CELL,k)+1$ " was used in MS Excel 2016 to determine the sample size ($n = 30$). A total of 28 (62.2%) personnel, comprising 16 females and 12 males, responded. Data analysis was performed using MS Excel 2016 and SPSS Version 26, applying Chi-square, Fisher's Exact Test, and Mann-Whitney U Test as appropriate to the data type and measurement scale.

Results: No significant association was found between gender and pressure to conform to traditional roles in personal and professional life ($\chi^2(1) = 1.197, p = .274, n = 28$, Cramer's $V = 0.207$, 95% CI $[-0.158, 0.574]$). A Cramer's V of approximately 0.21 suggests a small to medium effect size or strength of association between sex and feeling pressure in this sample. No evidence of gender discrimination in the workplace at DLS was found (Fisher's Exact Test, $p = .184, n = 28$, Cramer's $V = 0.251$, 95% CI $[-0.104, 0.520]$). Cramer's V of 0.251 indicates a small to medium strength of association between sex and workplace status in this sample. A significant association ($\chi^2(1) = 8.859, p = .003, n = 28$, Cramer's $V = 0.563$, 95% CI $[0.252, 0.873]$), indicating a large effect size. The Mann-Whitney U Test also showed a significant difference ($Md = 2, U = 53.5, p = .031$), with an effect size of $r = 0.407$, indicating a medium to large effect.

Conclusion: The study concluded that while gender does not significantly influence pressure to conform to traditional roles or workplace discrimination at the DLS, it significantly impacts career path choices. The findings support the alternative hypothesis regarding gender influence on career development and suggest a need for further exploration in this area.

Novelty: This study provides empirical evidence of gender's impact on career development decisions within a governmental department context in Nepal. It uniquely combines quantitative methods with a phenomenological approach and utilizes randomization techniques in participant selection, offering a data-driven foundation for advancing gender equality and enhancing workforce diversity and empowerment efforts.

Keywords: Career; Feeling pressure; Gender; Norms; Workplace.

Correspondence: Binod Kumar Adhikari, Central Department of Computer Science and Information Technology, TU, Nepal,
E-mail: bkadhikari@cdcsit.tu.edu.np.

INTRODUCTION

Gender encompasses the socially constructed roles, behaviors, identities, expectations, and psychological attributes associated with being male, female, or non-binary, which are distinct from biological sex [1, 2]. Gender norms and expectations vary across societies and social groups and can substantially influence individuals' behaviors, opportunities, relationships, education, employment, and career development [3, 4]. These norms also shape communication patterns, decision-making, and social interactions, and may restrict individuals'

aspirations when particular behaviors or characteristics are considered appropriate for men or women [5, 6]. Although gender norms are socially constructed and can therefore be challenged and transformed, persistent stereotypes continue to affect socialization, educational opportunities, career choices, and professional advancement [7, 8].

The influence of gender on career development begins early in life and is shaped by family expectations, education, socioeconomic conditions, cultural practices, access to information, and broader social norms [9, 10]. Tradi-

tional gender expectations may encourage boys and girls toward different educational and occupational pathways, potentially limiting career aspirations and opportunities. Gender-based discrimination, stereotypes, unequal access to resources, and restricted support networks can further affect career progression and advancement [11–13]. These challenges may persist in workplaces and educational institutions despite increasing emphasis on gender equality, inclusion, and legal protections against discrimination and harassment [14, 15].

In Nepal, gender equality and inclusion in the civil service have received increasing policy attention, including measures such as quotas for women's representation [16, 17]. Nevertheless, substantial gender disparities remain in public employment, particularly in senior positions and organizational representation. Recent reports indicate that men continue to constitute a large proportion of Nepal's civil service workforce, demonstrating the persistence of gender-related inequalities despite institutional efforts toward inclusion [18]. Such disparities highlight the importance of examining how gender norms, workplace discrimination, and career choices influence professional development within Nepal's public sector.

Livestock services constitute an important component of Nepal's agricultural civil service, and the Department of Livestock Services (DLS), Lalitpur, provides an appropriate institutional setting for examining these issues [19]. Although women have increasingly occupied senior positions within the DLS, gender-related influences on career development, workplace experiences, job assignments, transfers, responsibilities, and training opportunities remain insufficiently examined. Existing research has addressed gender equality, workplace discrimination, and career development in various sectors, but limited evidence is available regarding the relationship between gender and career development within Nepal's livestock service sector [20, 21].

Therefore, this study examines the relationship between gender and career development among personnel of the Department of Livestock Services (DLS), Lalitpur, Nepal. Specifically, the study determines the association between gender and pressure to conform to traditional gender roles in personal and professional settings, examines the relationship between gender and workplace discrimination, and assesses whether gender influences career-path selection. By addressing these dimensions, the study seeks to provide empirical evidence for promoting equitable job assignments, transfers, responsibilities, training opportunities, and career advancement within the livestock service sector.

MATERIALS AND METHODS

A quantitative cross-sectional study was conducted to examine the association between gender and selected dimensions of career development among personnel of the Department of Livestock Services (DLS), Hariharbawan, Lalitpur, Nepal. The study focused on three prin-

cipal dimensions of career development: pressure to conform to traditional gender roles in personal and professional life, experiences of workplace discrimination, and the influence of gender on career-path selection. The study was conducted from May 20 to 27, 2024.

The Department of Livestock Services had approximately 70 personnel. However, because some personnel were unavailable during the study period, 45 available personnel constituted the accessible study population. Considering the relatively small population size, 30 personnel were selected as the intended sample [22], representing approximately 66.7% of the accessible population. A sampling list containing the 45 available personnel was prepared, and a systematic selection procedure was applied using Microsoft Excel 2016. The sampling interval was calculated as $k = N/n$, where N represents the accessible population and n represents the intended sample size. The Excel MOD function was used to facilitate the selection of respondents from the sampling list. Of the 30 personnel selected, 28 completed the questionnaire, resulting in a response rate of 93.3%. The final analytical sample therefore consisted of 28 respondents, including 16 females and 12 males.

Primary data were collected using a structured, closed-ended questionnaire administered through Google Forms. The questionnaire was developed according to the objectives of the study and included questions concerning gender, pressure to conform to traditional gender roles, experiences of workplace discrimination, and career-path selection. The questionnaire was distributed electronically to the selected personnel during the study period. Participation was voluntary, and respondents were informed about the purpose of the study before completing the questionnaire. Only completed questionnaires were included in the final analysis.

Gender was considered the principal independent variable, while pressure to conform to traditional gender roles, workplace discrimination, and career-path selection were considered dependent variables. The first outcome assessed whether respondents experienced pressure to conform to traditional gender expectations in their personal and professional lives. The second examined respondents' experiences or perceptions of discrimination in the workplace. The third assessed the extent to which gender influenced the selection of a career path. Responses relating to career-path selection were measured using an ordinal scale and, because of the relatively small sample size, were categorized into three groups: 1 = no influence, 2 = influence between 40% and 60%, and 3 = influence above 60%. This categorization was used to facilitate appropriate non-parametric statistical analysis.

The collected data were compiled and analyzed using Microsoft Excel 2016 and IBM SPSS Statistics version 26. Descriptive statistics, including frequencies and percentages, were used to summarize the characteristics of respondents and the distribution of responses for the study variables. Inferential statistical procedures were selected according to the measurement scale and distribution of

the variables. The chi-square test of independence was used to examine associations between categorical variables where the assumptions of the test were satisfied. Fisher's exact test was applied when expected cell frequencies were small and the assumptions of the chi-square test were not adequately met. The Mann-Whitney U test was used for the ordinal career-path variable to compare the distribution of responses between male and female respondents. Statistical significance was assessed at the 5% significance level ($p < 0.05$) [23].

The study was limited to personnel who were available during the data-collection period and therefore may not fully represent all personnel employed by the Department of Livestock Services. Although career development may be influenced by several demographic, organizational, socioeconomic, and individual factors, the present study focused primarily on gender and its association with the selected career-development outcomes. Other potential explanatory variables were not included in the analysis and were considered constant (*ceteris paribus*). The study also relied on self-reported information obtained through a closed-ended online questionnaire. The relatively small sample size restricted the range of statistical procedures that could be appropriately applied. Therefore, the findings should be interpreted within the institutional and temporal context of the Department of Livestock Services, Lalitpur, during the study period.

Participation in the study was voluntary, and respondents were informed about the purpose and nature of the study before completing the questionnaire. The information provided by the respondents was treated confidentially and was used solely for academic research purposes.

RESULTS

A total of 30 personnel were selected for participation in the study, of whom 28 completed the questionnaire, resulting in a response rate of 93.3%. The final sample consisted of 16 females (57.1%) and 12 males (42.9%). The association between gender and feeling pressure to conform to traditional gender roles in personal and professional life is presented in Table 1. Among female respondents, 10 (62.5%) reported feeling pressure to conform to traditional gender roles, whereas 6 (37.5%) reported no such pressure. Among male respondents, 5 (41.7%) reported feeling pressure and 7 (58.3%) reported no pressure. Overall, 15 (53.6%) respondents reported feeling pressure to conform to traditional gender roles, compared with 13 (46.4%) who did not. The Pearson chi-square test showed no statistically significant association between gender and perceived pressure to conform to traditional gender roles, $\chi^2(1) = 1.197$, $p = 0.274$. The observed effect size, measured using Cramer's V , was $V = 0.207$, indicating a relatively small association. Thus, although a greater proportion of female respondents reported feeling pressure than male respondents, the observed difference was not statistically significant in this sample.

The relationship between gender and reported workplace

Table 1. Gender and feeling pressure to conform to traditional gender roles

Gender	Feeling Pressure			
	No	%	Yes	%
Female	6	37.5	10	62.5
Male	7	58.3	5	41.7
Total	13	46.4	15	53.6

Note: $\chi^2(1) = 1.197$, $p = 0.274$, Cramer's $V = 0.207$.

discrimination is shown in Table 2. A relatively high proportion of respondents reported experiencing workplace discrimination. Among females, 14 (87.5%) reported experiencing discrimination, while 2 (12.5%) reported no discrimination. Among males, 8 (66.7%) reported experiencing discrimination and 4 (33.3%) reported no discrimination. Overall, 22 (78.6%) respondents reported experiencing workplace discrimination. Although the proportion was higher among female respondents than male respondents, the Pearson chi-square test did not indicate a statistically significant association, $\chi^2(1) = 1.768$, $p = 0.184$. Because two cells (50.0%) had expected frequencies below 5, Fisher's exact test was considered more appropriate and likewise did not indicate a statistically significant association ($p = 0.184$). The corresponding Cramer's V was 0.251, suggesting a small-to-moderate association. Therefore, the results do not provide sufficient statistical evidence to conclude that reported workplace discrimination differed significantly by gender in the study population.

Table 2. Gender and reported workplace discrimination

Gender	Workplace Discrimination			
	No	%	Yes	%
Female	2	12.5	14	87.5
Male	4	33.3	8	66.7
Total	6	21.4	22	78.6

Note: Fisher's exact test $p = 0.184$; Cramer's $V = 0.251$.

A statistically significant association was observed between gender and the reported influence of gender on career-path selection (Table 3). Among female respondents, 13 (81.3%) reported that gender influenced their career-path selection, compared with only 3 (25.0%) male respondents. Conversely, 9 (75.0%) male respondents reported that gender did not influence their career-path selection, compared with 3 (18.8%) female respondents. Overall, 16 (57.1%) respondents reported that gender influenced their career-path selection, whereas 12 (42.9%) reported no influence. The Pearson chi-square test demonstrated a statistically significant association between gender and the perceived influence of gender on career-path selection, $\chi^2(1) = 8.859$, $p = 0.003$. Cramer's $V = 0.563$ indicated a relatively large association. The result suggests that female respondents were substantially more likely than male respondents to report that gender had influenced their career-path decisions.

The degree of perceived influence of gender on career-path selection was further examined using the Mann-

Table 3. Gender and perceived influence of gender on career-path selection

Gender	Influence on Career-Path Selection			
	No	%	Yes	%
Female	3	18.8	13	81.3
Male	9	75.0	3	25.0
Total	12	42.9	16	57.1

Note: $\chi^2(1) = 8.859$, $p = 0.003$; Cramer's $V = 0.563$.

Whitney U test (Table 4). Female respondents had a higher mean rank (17.16) than male respondents (10.96), indicating that females reported a greater degree of gender influence on career-path selection. The Mann-Whitney test produced $U = 53.5$ and $Z = -2.156$, with an asymptotic two-tailed significance value of $p = 0.031$. The effect size was $|r| = 0.407$, which represents a moderate effect according to commonly used benchmarks. These findings provide additional evidence that the perceived degree of gender influence on career-path selection differed between male and female respondents, with females reporting greater influence.

Table 4. Mann-Whitney U test for the degree of gender influence on career-path selection

Gender	N	Mean Rank	Sum of Ranks
Male	12	10.96	131.50
Female	16	17.16	274.50
Total	28		

Note: $U = 53.5$, $Z = -2.156$, $p = 0.031$; $|r| = 0.407$.

DISCUSSION

The present study examined whether gender was associated with perceived pressure to conform to traditional gender roles, workplace discrimination, and career-path selection among personnel of the Department of Livestock Services in Lalitpur, Nepal. The findings indicate that gender was not significantly associated with reported pressure to conform to traditional gender roles or workplace discrimination. However, gender was significantly associated with both the reported influence of gender on career-path selection and the degree of that influence. The findings therefore suggest that gender may operate less visibly through direct workplace experiences and more strongly through the formation of career preferences and career-related decisions.

The absence of a statistically significant association between gender and perceived pressure to conform to traditional gender roles should not necessarily be interpreted as evidence that gender-role expectations are absent. In the present sample, 62.5% of female respondents reported experiencing such pressure compared with 41.7% of male respondents. Although this difference did not reach statistical significance, the descriptive pattern suggests that women may experience greater pressure than men. The lack of statistical significance may partly reflect the small sample size and the limited statistical power of the study. This interpretation is consistent with broader research

demonstrating that gender-role expectations can shape individuals' perceptions and behavior even when their effects are not uniform across contexts. Schroeder and Liben [24] documented that felt pressure to conform to cultural gender roles is related to gender socialization and expectations communicated by parents and peers. Their findings were primarily based on younger populations, whereas the present study examined adult employees; therefore, the two studies should not be considered directly equivalent. Nevertheless, both suggest that gender-role expectations can remain relevant across different stages of the life course.

The finding is also relevant to the Nepalese context. Research on young Nepali women has shown that parental decisions and intervention can influence women's educational and work transitions and their imagined future careers [25]. Similarly, research on women employees in Nepal identified societal barriers as important constraints on career progression, with marriage and socially defined responsibilities emerging as particularly important barriers [26]. These studies provide contextual evidence that gendered social expectations continue to influence women's educational and occupational trajectories in Nepal, even though the present study did not find a statistically significant gender difference in reported pressure. Thus, the non-significant result should be interpreted cautiously rather than as evidence that traditional gender expectations have no relevance in the Nepalese workplace.

The second major finding concerned workplace discrimination. A large majority of respondents reported experiencing workplace discrimination, including 87.5% of female respondents and 66.7% of male respondents. Despite this substantial descriptive difference, Fisher's exact test did not show a statistically significant association between gender and reported discrimination ($p = 0.184$). This result differs from evidence from broader Nepalese research suggesting that women continue to encounter gender-related barriers in employment and organizational advancement. For example, Adhikary [26] found that societal and organizational barriers were perceived as important constraints on the career progression of Nepali women employees. More recent evidence on gender issues in Nepalese human resource management similarly reports continuing gender inequality, including unequal access to skills, training, resources, and higher-level positions [27]. Research specifically examining women in the Nepali civil service has also reported the persistence of gender stereotypes and gender-influenced behavior despite institutional efforts toward representative bureaucracy.

The difference between these findings and the present result may be explained partly by the design and scope of the studies. The present research examined a small group of personnel within one government department and focused on whether respondents reported workplace discrimination. In contrast, previous Nepalese studies have often examined broader structural barriers, career progression, representation, or qualitative experiences.

Consequently, the absence of a statistically significant association in the present study does not establish that workplace gender discrimination is absent from the DLS. Rather, it indicates that the available sample did not provide sufficient statistical evidence that reported discrimination differed according to gender. The high overall proportion of respondents reporting discrimination nevertheless warrants attention from institutional policymakers.

The strongest finding of the study was the significant association between gender and the perceived influence of gender on career-path selection. Female respondents were substantially more likely than male respondents to report that gender had influenced their career path: 81.3% of females compared with 25.0% of males. The association was statistically significant, $\chi^2(1) = 8.859$, $p = 0.003$, with a Cramer's V of 0.563. The Mann-Whitney U analysis provided convergent evidence, with female respondents having a higher mean rank than males (17.16 versus 10.96) and a statistically significant difference in the perceived degree of influence ($U = 53.5$, $p = 0.031$, $|r| = 0.407$).

This finding is consistent with international evidence showing that gender stereotypes can influence educational and occupational aspirations and career choices. A recent systematic review by Cardelli et al. [28] found that gender stereotypes are associated with gender-typical career interests and choices and with lower career aspirations among women, particularly for occupations traditionally viewed as masculine. Similarly, Correll [29] demonstrated that culturally shaped gender beliefs can influence individuals' assessments of their own competence and subsequently channel men and women toward different career directions. More recent OECD evidence also indicates that gender stereotypes at home, in educational settings, and in wider society contribute to differences in fields of study and career expectations. These findings provide a theoretical basis for interpreting the present result: gender may affect career development not only through explicit discrimination but also through socially constructed expectations regarding which careers are considered appropriate or achievable for women and men.

The present finding is particularly relevant to Nepal. Adhikari [25] reported that parental choices and interventions influenced young Nepali women's educational and work transitions, suggesting that career-related decisions may be shaped by social and family expectations. Similarly, research on women's representation in the Nepali civil service has documented the continuing importance of gendered social norms and institutional barriers despite the expansion of women's participation following the introduction of reservation policies [30]. Evidence from Nepal's civil service also shows gender differences in objective career outcomes. Tamang [31] found significant gender differences in objective career outcomes among 254 civil servants in Kathmandu Valley, although differences were not observed for all subjective career-success measures. The present study extends this literature by showing that, within the DLS, female personnel

were more likely to perceive gender itself as an influence on their career-path selection.

The significant result from the Mann-Whitney U test further strengthens the interpretation because it does not rely on the same categorical comparison used in the chi-square analysis. Female respondents had a considerably higher mean rank for the perceived degree of gender influence, and the effect size of approximately 0.41 indicates a moderate difference. However, the result should not be interpreted as demonstrating that gender causes career path decisions. The cross-sectional design measures association rather than causality, and the small sample size limits the generalizability of the findings. Other factors, including family expectations, socioeconomic conditions, education, organizational culture, career opportunities, personal interests, and geographic or household responsibilities, may also influence career choices but were not examined in the present study.

Overall, the findings indicate that the relationship between gender and career development in the DLS is multidimensional. The absence of statistically significant gender differences in reported pressure and workplace discrimination contrasts with the significant relationship between gender and career-path selection. This pattern suggests that gender-related influences may operate indirectly through expectations, socialization, perceived suitability of occupations, and career decision-making rather than solely through explicit workplace discrimination. This interpretation is consistent with evidence that gender stereotypes can shape career aspirations and choices even when formal institutional barriers have been reduced [28]. In Nepal, where policies such as gender quotas have contributed to increased female participation in the civil service, continued attention to career development, organizational culture, mentoring, training access, job assignments, and advancement opportunities remains important [32].

The findings should, however, be interpreted in light of several limitations. First, the final sample consisted of only 28 respondents from a single government department, which restricts statistical power and external validity. Second, the study relied on self-reported responses, which may be influenced by individual perceptions and willingness to disclose experiences of discrimination or gender-related pressure. Third, gender was examined as the principal explanatory variable while other potentially important determinants of career development were not included in the analysis. Finally, the categorization of the career-path influence variable into a limited number of ordinal categories was adopted because of the small sample size and should be considered when comparing the results with studies using continuous or multidimensional career-development measures.

Despite these limitations, the study provides preliminary empirical evidence that gender is significantly related to perceived career-path selection among personnel of the Department of Livestock Services. The findings support the need for gender-responsive career-development poli-

cies within public institutions, particularly in relation to career counseling, training opportunities, mentoring, job assignments, transfers, leadership development, and promotion. Future studies involving larger samples across multiple departments and levels of Nepal's civil service could provide stronger evidence regarding the mechanisms through which gender influences career development and could incorporate additional explanatory factors such as age, marital status, education, job level, years of service, family responsibilities, and organizational support.

CONCLUSIONS

This study examined the influence of gender on the pressure to conform to traditional roles, workplace discrimination, and career path selection among personnel at the Department of Livestock Services (DLS). The findings revealed no significant association between gender and the pressure to conform to traditional roles, nor any evidence of gender-based discrimination in the workplace. However, a statistically significant relationship was identified between gender and its influence on choosing a career path, with female respondents more likely to report such an impact. This suggests that while overt gender-based barriers may be diminishing in institutional settings like DLS, gender continues to shape career-related decisions in more subtle but meaningful ways.

Based on these findings, it is recommended that further research be conducted on a larger and more diverse population across different government and non-government sectors to validate and expand upon these insights. Future studies should also consider the intersectionality of gender with other variables such as ethnicity, socioeconomic status, and educational background. Additionally, institutional policies should be reviewed and strengthened to ensure gender-sensitive career development practices, promote mentorship opportunities, and raise awareness about unconscious gender biases. Such efforts will be instrumental in fostering a more equitable and inclusive work environment that supports diverse career aspirations for all individuals.

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